



THE MORNING KICKOFF

🏆 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Knockout stage — Round of 16, final day



The last two quarter-final places are decided tonight



Messi can take the Golden Boot lead outright tonight



All three host nations are out of their own World Cup

⚡ THE END OF AN ERA

NO FAIRY-TALE ENDING

A 91st-minute goal by substitute Mikel Merino sent Spain through and ended Cristiano Ronaldo's last World Cup — and before the night was over, Belgium had routed the host nation 4–1 in Seattle. The bracket has lost its biggest name and its loudest crowd in one evening.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ Crystal Ball, day one: the Spain call landed, the USA call didn't — the live market's 34% warning on Belgium aged very well.
- ⚡ USA, Mexico and Canada are all out — this World Cup will be lifted by a visiting nation.
- 📅 Rest day tomorrow, then the quarter-finals begin Thursday in Boston with France–Morocco.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 Portugal 0–1 Spain — Merino's late dagger and Ronaldo's quiet goodbye
- P.3 USA 1–4 Belgium — the hosts' dream dies loudly in Seattle
- P.4 Tonight: Messi's champions meet Egypt, then Switzerland–Colombia closes the round
- P.5 The Crystal Ball: tonight's calls, with live market prices — day one went 1 for 2
- P.6 Golden Boot: three still tied on 7, and one of them plays tonight
- P.7 The bracket: Spain–Belgium joins the quarter-final card



Cristiano Ronaldo — 19 touches in his final World Cup match, by his own word his last

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)



Argentina
– Egypt



18:00



Switzerland –
Colombia



22:00

FULL PREVIEWS
PAGE 4



THE MORNING
KICKOFF

Tuesday 7 July 2026 · Edition #2 · Results & stats: ESPN, CBS Sports, FIFA, Opta Analyst, CNN, NBC, FOX Sports, Olympics.com — checked morning of 7 July 2026. Live market prices: Kalshi. Kick-off times in Central European Time unless flagged otherwise.

⚡ FAREWELL

📍 AT&T Stadium, Dallas



Portugal

0 – 1

FULL TIME

Spain



⊗ Merino 91' · near post

For 90 minutes the Iberian derby was a chess game Portugal refused to lose — and then Luis de la Fuente's bench decided it. Ferran Torres, on in the second half, slipped a quick ball into the box in the 91st minute and Mikel Merino, the other substitute, buried it at the near post. Portugal never mustered a shot on target after the break.

It ends the international road of Cristiano Ronaldo, who had confirmed this would be his final tournament. Just 19 touches, the second-fewest of his World Cup career as a starter, while Rodri quietly ran the evening: 106 touches and 87 completed passes. Spain march into a Friday quarter-final against Belgium having still not conceded a goal.

MATCH TIMELINE

● Spain above · ● Portugal below



★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Mikel Merino

On the pitch for the finish that settled a derby of fine margins — a near-post strike in the 91st minute, seconds after his fellow substitute created it.



Ronaldo, 41

Five World Cups, and a last one that ended with a whimper rather than a roar. He leaves the stage with the tournament still missing from his shelf.

🔗 Both goal-makers came off the bench: Ferran Torres slipped the pass, Merino finished at the near post

⊗ Ronaldo touched the ball just 19 times — his second-fewest in a World Cup match he started

🏆 Spain are still yet to concede a single goal at this World Cup

➔ **WHAT IT MEANS** Spain meet Belgium in Friday's Los Angeles quarter-final (18:00). Portugal's golden generation era closes without the one trophy it wanted most.

⚡ UPSET

📍 Lumen Field, Seattle · Att. 66,925



United States

1 – 4

FULL TIME



Belgium

⚽ Tillman 31' · free kick

⚽ De Ketelaere 9', 33' · double

⚽ Vanaken 57'

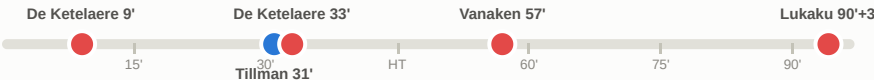
⚽ Lukaku 90'+3

The night Seattle had waited a generation for lasted nine minutes. Charles De Ketelaere finished a flowing move to silence 66,925, and though Malik Tillman's 31st-minute free kick briefly lit the stadium back up, De Ketelaere struck again 90 seconds later. The reinstated Folarin Balogun and the home attack managed just two shots on target all night.

Matt Freese's error handed Hans Vanaken the third just before the hour, and substitute Romelu Lukaku added a fourth in stoppage time. Belgium out-attempted the hosts 15–7 and looked, for the first time this tournament, like the team their squad list promises. The USMNT's home World Cup ends in the round of 16 — and with it, the last host standing is gone.

MATCH TIMELINE

● Belgium above · ● United States below



■ United States

■ Belgium



★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Charles De Ketelaere

Two goals in the opening 33 minutes, the second a dagger thrown 90 seconds after the hosts had found hope. The quiet man of Belgium's new generation owned the loudest room in the tournament.



Malik Tillman

His curled free kick was the USMNT's one moment of joy — and at 24, part of the core that will carry the lessons of this night to 2030.

⚡ De Ketelaere's second came barely a minute after Tillman's free kick had levelled the mood

🚩 Goalkeeper Matt Freese's mistake gifted Belgium their third early in the second half

🔗 The 'flat and leggy' Belgium of the group stage produced their sharpest 90 minutes of the tournament

➔ WHAT IT MEANS Belgium meet unbeaten Spain in Friday's Los Angeles quarter-final. All three host nations are out before the last eight.

THE CHAMPIONS' TEST



Argentina

VS

Egypt



🇸🇰 🇪🇸 🇮🇹 18:00 🇮🇪 19:00 🇮🇳 21:30 🇨🇦 12:00 🇲🇽 10:00

Kick-off 12:00 PM ET at the stadium

📍 Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta

The defending champions have won all four games, but the last one took 120 minutes against Cape Verde — and Egypt arrive from a penalty-shootout epic of their own against Australia, deep in the best World Cup in their history. Messi, 39, has scored seven of Argentina's eleven goals; Mohamed Salah carries just as much of Egypt's hopes.

- 👁️ **Messi can take the Golden Boot lead outright with his eighth**
- 👁️ **Two tired teams: both needed 120 minutes to survive the last 32**



KEY MAN · EGYPT

Mohamed Salah

Egypt's captain and talisman, leading his country through its best-ever World Cup — and the one player Argentina will genuinely fear.

THE LAST TICKET



Switzerland

VS

Colombia



🇸🇰 🇪🇸 🇮🇹 22:00 🇮🇪 23:00 🇮🇳 01:30 +1 🇨🇦 16:00 🇲🇽 14:00

Kick-off 1:00 PM PT at the stadium

📍 BC Place, Vancouver

The round closes with a genuine clash of styles: Switzerland's disciplined, tactically rigid block against a Colombia side that wants the ball and attacks in waves of technique. Colombia edged Ghana to get here but sweat on striker Jhon Córdoba, who lasted only eight minutes of that game.

- 👁️ **Colombia's flair against a organised Swiss block — patience will be everything**
- 👁️ **The winner gets Argentina or Egypt in Sunday's Kansas City quarter-final**



KEY MAN · COLOMBIA

Luis Díaz

Colombia's most dangerous attacker — direct, relentless, and exactly the type to unpick a deep Swiss defence one duel at a time.

⚽ THE ROUND OF 16 SO FAR

Six ties done — two to decide tonight

🇸🇰 Morocco 3 – 0 Canada 🇨🇦

Sat

🇫🇷 France 1 – 0 Paraguay 🇵🇷

Sat

🇧🇷 Brazil 1 – 2 Norway 🇳🇴

Sun

🇲🇽 Mexico 2 – 3 England 🇬🇧

Sun

TOMORROW: REST DAY — THE QUARTER-FINALS START THURSDAY



Argentina v Egypt



★ OUR CALL: ARGENTINA 2-0

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO REACH THE QUARTER-FINAL



⚡ LIVE MARKET · KALSHI PREDICTION MARKET · REGULATION-TIME WINNER · \$1.5M TRADED

Argentina 72%

Tie 20%

Egypt 9%

FORM

Argentina have won all four games, but needed 120 minutes to shake off Cape Verde; Egypt survived Australia only on penalties after their own 120.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Messi and Salah have never faced each other at a World Cup — Egypt missed 2022, and the 2018 draw kept them apart. A first, and possibly a last.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

Both sides went the full 120 in the last 32 on the same day, so the rest ledger is even — but Egypt also carried the emotional load of a shootout.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Kalshi's live market (\$1.5m traded) is emphatic: Argentina 72%, the draw 20%, Egypt just 9% in regulation. Nobody is betting on the fairy tale.

⚡ THE VERDICT

The champions have looked mortal for 120 minutes at a time, but never beatable. Egypt's block will hold for a while; Messi tends to decide what happens after that. Argentina, comfortably enough — and perhaps the outright Golden Boot lead with it.



Switzerland v Colombia



★ OUR CALL: COLOMBIA 2-1

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO REACH THE QUARTER-FINAL



⚡ LIVE MARKET · KALSHI PREDICTION MARKET · REGULATION-TIME WINNER · \$378K TRADED

Switzerland 27%

Tie 32%

Colombia 43%

FORM

Colombia edged past Ghana in the last 32 and have grown into the tournament; Switzerland have ground their way here on structure and set pieces.

THE MATCH-UP

A pure clash of styles: Switzerland's disciplined, deep block against Colombia's aggressive, technical possession game. Patience against pressure.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

Colombia sweat on striker Jhon Córdoba, who lasted just eight minutes against Ghana before going off injured.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

The quietest market of the round (Kalshi, \$378k): Colombia 43%, Switzerland 27% — and a round-high 32% on the draw. The money smells extra time.

⚡ THE VERDICT

The draw price is the story: a third of the market expects this level after 90 minutes. We take Colombia's extra quality to tell eventually — but if Córdoba is out and the Swiss block settles in, nobody should be surprised by penalties in Vancouver.

The Crystal Ball is for family bragging rights only. Probabilities blend live prediction-market prices with our own reading of form, fitness and history. Entertainment — not financial or betting advice. Day-one record: 1 of 2.



Kylian Mbappé

2 assists — holds the tie-breaker into the quarter-finals

7



Lionel Messi

Plays Egypt tonight — one goal takes the lead outright

7



Erling Haaland

Rests until Saturday's quarter-final against England

7

1 **Kylian Mbappé** France · 2 assists

2 **Lionel Messi** Argentina · plays tonight

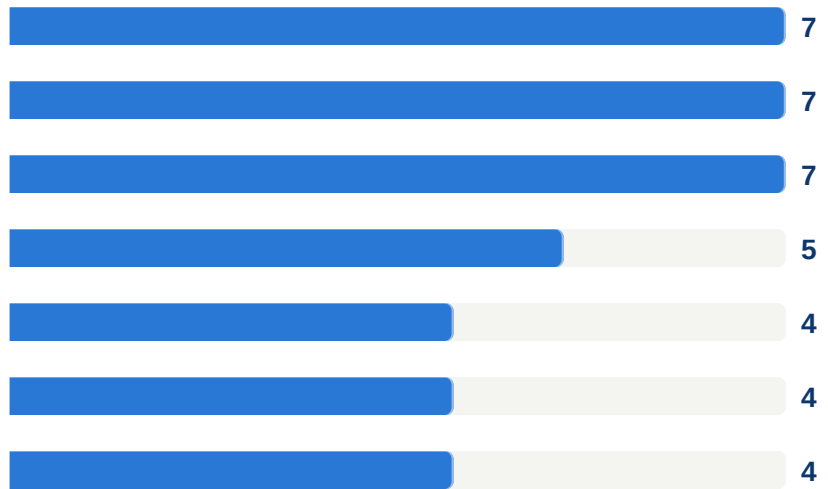
3 **Erling Haaland** Norway

4 **Harry Kane** England

5 **Vinícius Júnior** Brazil · eliminated

6 **Mikel Oyarzabal** Spain · faces Belgium Friday

7 **Ousmane Dembélé** France



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Mbappé leads on 2 assists — but only Messi of the three plays tonight.

NUMBERS OF THE DAY

19

Ronaldo's touches in his final World Cup game — his 2nd-fewest in a match he started

0

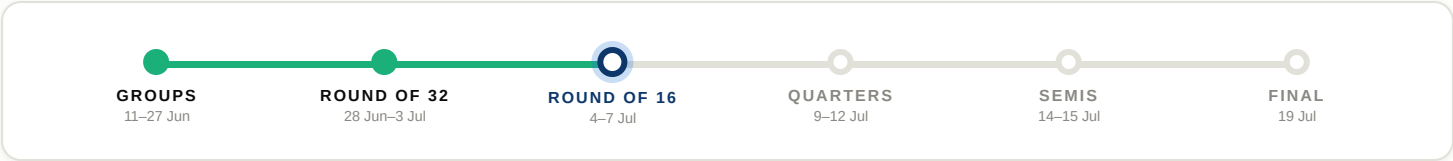
Goals conceded by Spain in the entire tournament so far

4–1

Belgium's rout in Seattle — the third and last host nation eliminated

7 of 11

Argentina's tournament goals scored by Messi, 39, who plays tonight



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · Thu 9 July · 22:00 · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · Fri 10 July · 18:00 · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · Sat 11 July · 23:00 · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · Sun 12 July · 02:00 (+1) · Kansas City

Argentina / Egypt

Switzerland / Colombia

SEMI-FINALS

Tue 14 July · Dallas

Winners QF1 vs QF2

Wed 15 July · Atlanta

Winners QF3 vs QF4

THE FINAL

Sunday 19 July

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Monday 6 — Sunday 12 July

TUE
7 Jul

Argentina–Egypt · 18:00

Switzerland–Colombia · 22:00

WED
8 Jul

Rest day — the last 8 are set

THU
9 Jul

QF1 France–Morocco · 22:00

FRI
10 Jul

QF2 Spain–Belgium · 18:00

SAT
11 Jul

QF3 Norway–England · 23:00

SUN
12 Jul

QF4 in Kansas City · 02:00 (+1)

MON
13 Jul

Rest day — semi-finals loom



See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the last-eight card is complete — full reports on tonight's two deciders, plus our quarter-final preview special.

Player photos: Yantsimages (CC BY-SA 4.0), Biso (CC BY 4.0), Bryan Berlin (CC BY-SA 4.0), Анна Нэсси (CC BY-SA 3.0), Werner100359 (CC BY-SA 4.0), via Wikimedia Commons.